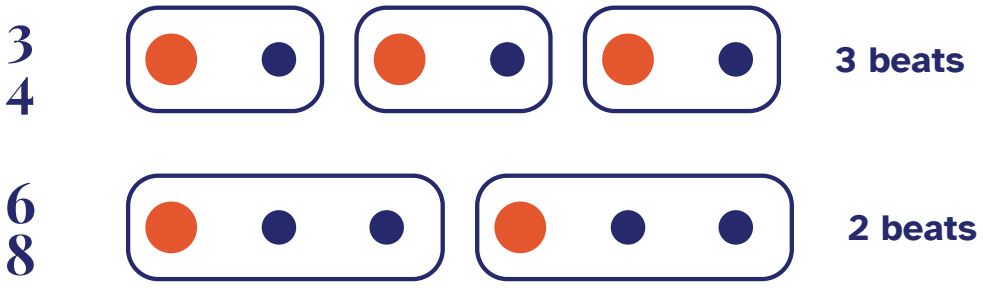
PART II · TIME · 5

# Compound and irregular time

Compound time is a skipping rope: each dotted beat splits into **three**. Irregular time keeps you guessing, with **five or seven** counts in uneven groups. (9/4, 12/4 and /16 signatures are rare.)

**THE SECRET**

**Dotted beats split in three: 6/8 is two big beats.**




*Same six quavers, new groups*

**SIMPLE OR COMPOUND?**

In **simple time** each beat divides into **two**. In **compound time** each beat is a dotted note and divides into **three**.

**Quick test:** a top number of 6, 9 or 12 means compound. Divide it by 3 to find the beats: 6/8 has 2, 9/8 has 3, 12/8 has 4.

## Compound time

| TIME SIGNATURE | EACH BAR HOLDS | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|
| 6/8 | 2 dotted crotchets | Level 1 |
| 9/8 | 3 dotted crotchets | Level 3 |
| 12/8 | 4 dotted crotchets | Level 3 |
| 6/4 | 2 dotted minims | Level 4 |

## Counting 6/8




Slowly, count all six quavers. At speed, feel two beats, on 1 and 4: “1 & a, 2 & a”.

PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

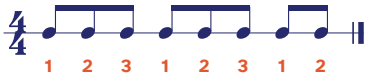
## Irregular time

Five or seven counts, grouped unevenly. Met from Level 5.

| TIME SIGNATURE | EACH BAR HOLDS | FIRST MET |
|---|---|---|
| 5/4 | 5 crotchets: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3 | Level 5 |
| 7/4 | 7 crotchets: 4 + 3 or 3 + 4 | *Extra* |
| 5/8 | 5 quavers: 3 + 2 or 2 + 3 | *Extra* |
| 7/8 | 7 quavers: 2 + 2 + 3 or 3 + 2 + 2 | *Extra* |

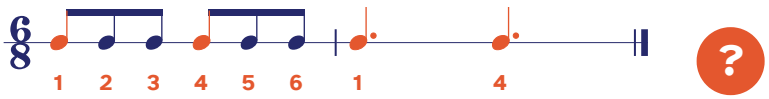
### UNEVEN GROUPS IN 4/4

Many dances keep 4/4 but group the eight quavers 3 + 3 + 2: “1 2 3, 1 2 3, 1 2”.




EXAMPLE 1

### How many beats in a bar of 6/8?




1. **Slowly, count all six quavers.**
2. **Which two counts** feel strong? (the red notes)
3. **Faster, count only the strong ones.** How many?

6/8 has **two beats** in a bar (1 and 4), each split into three quavers.

GAME

### Two beats or three?

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 |
|---|---|---|---|
| 6/8 | 3/4 | 9/8 | 2/4 |

How many beats in a bar, and does each beat split in two or in three?

Answer: 1 two, in threes · 2 three, in twos · 3 three, in threes · 4 two, in twos.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

6/8

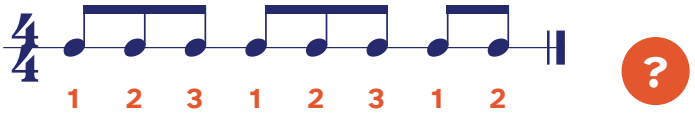
### Sway left, sway right.

Say “1 2 3, 4 5 6” and sway once on 1 and once on 4. That is 6/8: six quavers, two big beats.

PART II · TIME · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

**Is this still 4/4?**




1. **Count eight quavers** in the bar.
2. **Group them 3 + 3 + 2:** where do the accents fall?
3. **Keep your foot on the beat.** How many foot taps?

Accents on 1, 4 and 7, but four foot taps: the bar is still **4/4**, only the accents are uneven.

EXAMPLE 3

**How many beats in 9/8?**



1. **The top number, 9:** does it divide by 3?
2. **How many groups of three** fit in 9?
3. **What is each beat**, in quavers?

9 ÷ 3 = **three beats**, each a dotted crotchet: “1 2 3, 4 5 6, 7 8 9”.

HOW TO

**Feel compound time**

1. **Say “pine-ap-ple”** on every beat and step only on “pine”.
2. **Clap the three syllables** while you step.

YOU KNOW THIS

**Row, Row, Row Your Boat**




Two big beats in every bar, each a **dotted crotchet**: “Row, row”. Each big beat is worth three quavers: “row your” is long-short, a crotchet and a quaver, filling one big beat. That is 6/8.

**Try it.** Sway twice per bar while you sing it.

THINK OF IT Like a skipping rope: two big swings, each with three little steps inside.

TRAP

- × Counting 6/8 as six slow beats at speed: feel two big ones.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: the same six quavers, grouped differently.

SEE ALSO

Time signatures p. 59 · Rhythm: groups and upbeats p. 65

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Levels 1–4 · Compound time · Online: Rhythm clock